are stunned. Is this really happening to us again? The crowd is suddenly quiet. Surely it can't happen again.

Mark Boucher and Albie Morkel are still out there. We need 126 to avoid disaster and qualify with a better run rate, and they fight, ball by ball, run by run, reaching 101 for five in the 16th over. We are still battling and, when Mark is unfortunate to be bowled for 36, we need 25 runs from 21 balls with four wickets in hand.

It doesn't happen. We finish on 116, 10 runs short of salvation. We lose. We're out. Nobody says the C-word in our crushed changing room. Nobody needs to say the C-word, but it's the first question for Graeme at the post-match press conference: 'Why did the Proteas choke again?'

There is no easy answer.

The team has lost. I haven't scored any runs. It's a tough night in Durban. Over a couple of beers, quietly, I am starting to despair. I feel average. Mediocre. I need to be so much better than this. Am I going to be dropped? One of the cricket writers says it is time to rest me and give someone else a chance. No one is safe. Even Jacques Kallis was left out of the Twenty20 side. My position has become perilous.

I feel as though I'm hanging on by my fingertips when I am named in the squad that, just a week after the catastrophe at Kingsmead, flies to Pakistan to play two Test matches, in Karachi and then in Lahore, followed by five one-day internationals. Keep your head down, I tell myself. Keep working hard, keep putting the team first. If I can make the changes that are necessary, I will get through this tricky patch.

The tour to Pakistan goes well – both for the team and for me. We win the first Test by 160 runs, and I score 77 in our first innings. The second Test is drawn, and I make 45 and eight not out.

Life gets even better when, in the first one-day international, Herschelle and I make centuries and we win by 45 runs. Confidence is starting to return and, although the home side wins the second and third ODIs, we recover to win the fourth and fifth, following our Test series win with a